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Reflective Writing: From Document Analysis to Professional Growth

Authoring a rhetorical analysis of a technical document required identifying numerous related sources and ensuring that they are both accurate and useful. This process of organizing and performing a rigorous analysis to determine which sources should be utilized as the foundation of the project developed many related skills that will be utilized throughout my professional career. A source must be identified before it can be evaluated, which is a process requiring a combination of a myriad of skills. The *Analysis of a Professional Document* project required identifying, analyzing, and verifying diverse sets of documents, ranging from online articles and foundational technical proposals like the Rust RFC "pattern-binding-modes" to video interviews. A clear example was validating the video interview by Dr. Julian Edwards on RFC history that I included for the project. While it contained conversational segments of intermediate value, thorough analysis allowed me to extract the exact historical context necessary to frame how RFCs govern technical consensus within an open-source community.

The skills learned throughout this project will assist in future document writing. In my career I will have to author many documents in genres that I have little familiarity in. These skills in rhetorical analysis will serve me in these situations and ensure that my output retains the same professional quality across all scenarios. I will have to work across many different domains which all utilize diverse types of genres of documents. Especially when beginning a new position in this domain, where many of the common forms of communication will be unfamiliar to me. Stepping into a software engineering team as a junior developer often means opening an unfamiliar repository and being expected to navigate internal RFCs, architecture proposals, or strict pull request templates that nobody explicitly sat down to teach you. It is

critical within these new roles, as a new hire at an organization, that I adapt quickly and learn these new formats, with all of their unique rules and expectations. The skills developed throughout the *Analysis of a Professional Document* project will be integral to performing well in those environments.

I found the process of identifying sources particularly difficult, and it was here that I grew the most. I now have the skills required to analyze sources and determine their utility, which will remain highly valuable throughout my career. Across the many documents I have analyzed for this project, I have learned that I still require much growth in actually producing professional documents of a high quality. There are many expectations to be held within the industry and I must continue improving my ability to author in order to meet them. In particular, I can improve in areas of technical explanation, analytical depth, and domain expertise. Breaking down intricate systems, like explaining how pattern-matching ergonomics function under the hood without overwhelming readers who only need a high-level summary, demonstrated that balancing conciseness with technical precision requires continuous, deliberate practice.

In order to continue my development I should begin preparations to join my industry. I will research and analyze more examples of technical documentation within the field, identifying the key areas in which I must practice to meet their level of professionalism. As I work through my own projects as a student, especially in collaborative programming courses and upcoming senior design milestones, I will incorporate workplace-grade documentation wherever possible. In this way, my skills in technical documentation will develop over time, allowing me to enter the software engineering field with a mature, well-honed set of communicative capabilities.